

Yet, it is a gadget that could well be the ultimate achievement of mankind. Are we dreaming? Maybe. But if the ultimate objective of physics is to find the Grand Unified Theory, the ultimate objective of personal technology should be a gadget that can do all of the above, and more. Most of all, the gadget will serve to make the world smaller than ever before, and create a world that has answers at its fingertips.

Sociologically, though, it will be a nightmare, further dividing the haves and the have-nots. But then, what gadget or technology has not divided the world? Today's world, more than ever before, is cleaved into the haves and the have-nots. If 20 million people in India have access to the Internet, there are 980 million who do not. If there are 160 million people with access to TV, there are 840 million who don't.

Despite these daunting figures, it is only inevitable that technology will move towards this machine. It may not be called Opium (anyone with a better name can send their suggestions to editor@thinkdigit.com), but it will be there.

To be sure, building such a gadget would not be too much of a problem. As aviation experts put it when the Airbus 380, the world's biggest passenger plane, was in flight: "It is only a matter of scaling up." Today, the strongest candidate for such a universal machine is the humble cellular phone. Build

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the devices around the cell phone, and you would slowly, but surely, move towards the ultimate converged device.

However, the bigger issues will be: Who will provide the surrounding infrastructure to support information of all kinds on a machine like the Opium? Will the government address the bandwidth issue to clear broadcast issues? Will ultra-wideband technology become *de rigueur*? Will wireless data access be cheap enough for the common man to access without restriction?

We don't know the answers yet, and it would be foolish to hazard a guess. We wouldn't want to predict what government regulations could be, nor can we even predict what the public's reaction would be. What if we never take to the Opium, just as we never took to the Apple Newton?

Admittedly, the Opium will not take us even a step closer to Utopia. At best, it may create a new army of technocrats. No technology in the history of mankind has been ubiquitous, none omnipresent. It would be wrong to assume that the ultimate convergence device would be a ubiquitous device. The presence of such a device in anybody's hand would be more of an exception than the rule. It would definitely mean that humans have advanced technologically to a very high degree, but not so much as to turn technological utopia into reality. That, unfortunately, would remain a topic for science fiction novels. ■